

Outline for Classes

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How to Use This Information

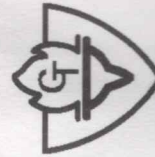
Like most extensive studies, this one evolved. And like most extensive studies, it is very difficult for someone who has not done the background study, and who has not done the extensive thinking about the subject, to be able to understand the material thoroughly, or to understand how to present it to others. Though, without doubt, the information in this work can be learned more easily by someone who already has an extensive knowledge of the Bible, I also firmly believe that one who does *not* have this knowledge can use this information to prepare himself for future Bible study.

I am very aware that some who read this work will do so to teach it to others. The very reason why I have decided to publish this material is because it has been requested so many times for use in a class. But there are those who will obtain this booklet for their own study. I must keep this in mind as we go along. I would hope that even someone who obtains this work for his own study will eventually teach it. Therefore, in presenting the material I have decided to follow the format that I use in teaching it, including all the little techniques that I use. The student who is studying the information for his own use can ignore these teacher's suggestions to the extent he wishes. Likely, however, he will find them helpful even for his own personal use.

One other suggestion on how to use this material: it would be better not to read and pore over the entire work to begin with. The amount of material can be frightening and intimidating. Rather, study the first cycle. When you have learned it, and can recite it

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from memory, move on to the second cycle. By the time you have reached the third cycle, you will be getting quite comfortable with the earlier information.

Objectives

This section will not be long, but anyone who plans to teach this material needs to think about these points until they are clear, and until he sees the importance of them. But I usually do not start out my class by listing these objectives. I do, however, incorporate them into my presentation as I go.

There are several objectives. First, we want to etch into the students' minds the basic facts of Bible history. It is a well-established fact that effective repetition is more helpful in learning than one prolonged exposure. Learning done in cycles that are repeated provide for this effective repetition. In this material we set forth three cycles of repetition. Notice how we emphasize this objective in our presentation.

Second, this material provides organization for the knowledge that is gained from Bible study. Through this organization we hope to provide better access to the knowledge one has. This organization also helps a more nearly permanent retention of knowledge. This is probably the most specific and important objective in this study. We will stress this point graphically in our presentation.

Third, we want the student to see that the Bible records the fulfillment of a plan, God's plan for the ages. This study takes the student through the Bible three times, and it does it in such a way that the student has to look at the Bible story as a whole.

Presentation

I am going to present thoughts for you, the reader and user of this system, that I do not necessarily give in my classes on the subject. I will put these thoughts in italics. I teach the subject under all kinds of circumstances, sometimes in a quarter of study, sometimes in a week of morning classes, sometimes in three classes during a

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meeting, sometimes in a fifteen minute session before each evening sermon during a gospel meeting. But if circumstances permit, I like to recommend that the study be the prelude to a three or four year course of study through the whole Bible.

When I can have a whole quarter to teach the material in these pages, I spend a lot of time in drill and practice. I also spend a lot of time, to begin with, explaining the purpose of this organizational material.

This material is effective by itself to help people be prepared to remember what they learn, but it is especially effective if used to prepare a class to study the three and a half to four year course of Bible study we advocate. One of the things that make this such an effective learning system is that each succeeding cycle reinforces the preceding one. In so many cases we study something and then stash it over in a corner where we have no exposure to it again for years. No wonder we have trouble learning. Envision this system as one in which we lay down a track or pattern, then we go back and retrace the pattern and build a framework on the track or pattern. As the framework goes up, we do not forget the pattern; we reinforce it.

So often we learn facts that are isolated. They are never integrated into our "web" or network of Bible knowledge. The result is that we tend to forget the fact and have no idea where it is. Let me use two illustrations to show how the approach in this material helps solve this problem. One involves an enormous warehouse. Someone brings a vase to be stored. We put the vase in an unmarked box. We put that box into a much larger box that contains lots of other boxes. This box is also unmarked. Then we take the whole box on a forklift back to the innards of the warehouse and stack it on other boxes just like it. The warehouse is not divided into sections, or rows, or anything. Six months later, the person comes back and asks for his vase. We have no memory that there was a vase, and we certainly have no idea where it is. If we had marked the box with the vase, and labeled the contents of the bigger box, and had divided the warehouse into sections, rows, shelves, etc., we could go right to the vase.

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Many of us are now familiar with computers. They have something called a hard disk drive, capable of storing vast amounts of information. Without organization, however, one would have no idea at all where something is on his hard drive. In fact, even with organization, sometimes one can forget how he filed a document. For this reason, a document needs to have an easily remembered name, a name that is very specific in describing the document, so that when one thinks of the document, the name will come to mind, and he can remember how he filed it. Once one is very familiar with his own hard drive, he knows how he has it organized, and can look up his files with comparative ease. What we are discussing in this work is the creation of an organizational framework in the mind. With this framework, information can be stored in the mind so that it can be recalled with more success.

It is necessary for students to see the need for this approach, and to see how this approach will solve the need. This approach is based on a good deal of study about how learning takes place.

Effective learning means having impressive repetitions of the material to be learned; it requires linking what is learned into a network. The more our new information is linked with facts already in our minds, the stronger the network. And it requires good drill work. Imagine an object suspended by a single strand of a spider's silk. That object's position is very fragile. This object corresponds to a fact that we wish to store permanently in our memory. The more threads that are attached to that memory, the less fragile its place is in our memory. The threads are associations. The more associations we have with a fact, and especially the more "cross references" there are, the more securely that fact will be in our mind. This phenomenon also explains why it is easier to learn one fact about something one already knows than to learn a fact in a subject about which one knows nothing. When one has a network of knowledge already established, it is simple to incorporate another fact into it.

I do not start out handing out notes to the students. Nor do I let them write notes at first. We usually write things down, place them

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in a forgotten drawer, and never learn them. So I take the students at least through the first cycle before anything is written down, and then I stress that the only reason for writing anything down is to have the information so that one can use it to drill the memory. I tell them that they do not need to be writing anything down, because shortly I will give them a full set of notes.

It is important to create the feeling that this is all easy, because it is not the difficulty of this information that makes it hard to learn; it is how we feel about learning that information that makes it hard or easy. So I do a lot of pep-talking during these weeks. Also, as we go along, and as the students begin to accumulate some knowledge, I like to use examples to show how this information is helping them to use the Bible more effectively.

I usually take a couple of classes on this first cycle, and when we have finished the second class, I have them name the periods and categories backwards. I coach them along a little by asking the right question, but they will be able to do it remarkably well. If you are studying this material for yourself, you will be able to do also.

First Cycle: Periods of Bible History

The objective in this cycle is primarily to learn the list of periods of Bible history and how they link together. Do not just memorize them, but seek to understand how they are related, how one leads to the next. Here I draw on the technique of "linking" information together so that to think of one suggests either the one before or the one after as well. These topics are mostly periods and events of the Bible, but at least one is a category of information. I make the point that the Bible is not just historical material; it also contains doctrinal material, such as the epistles. Our goal is to create a directory, or a pigeon hole, for every fact in the Bible. Sometimes one may choose to modify these periods/categories. Remember that there is a fine line between having too many of the periods on the one hand and having too few on the other. We could break Bible history into 79 periods, but if you faced the task of learning 79 things in order, or if you informed a class that they now had the task of learning 79

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things, they would immediately write the task off as impossible. On the other hand, we could divide the Bible into two categories, say, the Old and New Testaments, but this organization would be too general to do us any good. Before you alter this list, give it at least as much thought as I have.

Following is a concise list of the periods and categories of Bible history. Please understand that the purpose for this list is just so you will have the names of the periods and categories together so that you can quickly review them. Do not start in to learn them from this list. Skip the list for now and go through the first cycle.

Periods of Bible History

1. Before the flood
2. The flood
3. Scattering of the people
4. The Patriarchs
5. The Exodus
6. Wandering in the wilderness
7. Invasion and conquest of the land
8. The Judges
9. The United Kingdom
10. The Divided Kingdom
11. Judah alone
12. The captivity
13. Return from captivity
14. Years of silence
15. Life of Christ
16. Early church
17. Letters to Christians.

Before the Flood

These stories occur at or near the time of the creation. Our link is the idea that "*before* the flood" suggests that the next period is the flood, because this first period includes everything *before* the flood. Some might be tempted to call this period the "Ante-deluvian Age." Thus we have a word that sounds very intellectual instead

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of an easily understood one. I know what it means, but since my desire as a teacher is for people to understand me, I would never use the word in a study like this.

At this point, I pretend to be very serious, and I call upon the class to see if they can name the periods we have learned thus far. Can everyone handle one period? Everybody smiles, but the point I am really making is: "This is easy." If people are frightened by the difficulty of learning, they will not do it, so I spend a lot of time assuring them that this is easy.

If the first period in the Bible is "Before the flood," what would the next one be? Sometimes people say, "After the flood." The problem with that designation is it is too broad, because the day we live in is "after the flood," too. Besides, "before the flood" and "after the flood" skips the flood itself, so the next period is:

The Flood

Almost everyone has heard of Noah and the flood. The link with the preceding period is the name of that period. "Before the flood" reminds us that next comes "The Flood." The link with the next period is that Noah and his family grew and moved down from Mount Ararat until his descendants came to the plain of Shinar where they built the tower of Babel. An association does not have to be logical, just so it works. With gestures I merely indicate the height of Mount Ararat, then down to the valley of Mesopotamia, then the height of the tower of Babel. This helps to create the link with the next period or episode. Okay, let's try naming both periods we have learned so far. Can we handle that? At this point, I lead the class in saying, "Before the flood," "the Flood." That was no problem, was it?

Scattering of the People

Tower of Babel. The link is that after the tower of Babel, the families separated. Shem's family stayed more or less in the vicinity of Mesopotamia. From Shem comes Abraham, and Abraham was one of the patriarchs. If you are working with a group, and

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you can see that they do not have any knowledge of a particular period or event, you will have to give them a very tiny thumbnail sketch of the story, but ruthlessly resist the temptation to turn this first cycle into a six week study. If you do not heed this advice, you might as well take a gun and shoot yourself in the foot right now and get it over with. Remember! Multiple exposures to the forest will help learning and retention better than long, protracted study of the leaves.

Another problem is that some want to combine this period with either the flood or the patriarchs and have sixteen periods. The problem is that the tower of Babel does not fit with the flood or with the patriarchs. It is a very significant development that does not belong with the period before or after. It defeats the very point of having a separate category for every significant period of the Bible story.

The Patriarchs

Patriarch means "Father-Ruler." In the day of the patriarchs, there were many, but when we talk about the patriarchs, we are talking about three: Abraham, Isaac, Jacob. In addition to these characters, we include Joseph. The story of Joseph connects Genesis to Exodus. In his day the family of Israel moves down into Egypt. His story explains why, at the beginning of the book of Exodus, the Israelites are in Egypt. The link with the next period is that the Israelites did not stay in Egypt forever. At some point they *exited* Egypt, and Exodus is just a word meaning "going forth." Often, it is good to say, "If you didn't get everything this time, don't worry. This is not the last time we will go over this. Remember that the next cycle will reinforce this one, and you will be able to learn everything." Say the periods again.

The Exodus

In this period we include from the opening of the book of Exodus until the events at Kadesh-barnea because during all this time Israel was "going forth" toward Canaan until they reached Kadesh-barnea. The sin they committed there required punishment, and that punishment was *wandering in the wilderness*.

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Wandering in the Wilderness

This period includes such stories as Korah, Dathan, Abiram, and Balaam and his donkey. Since this is one of the most poorly known periods, I mention a few well known stories, but be careful here not to jump into the second cycle, which deals with the events of this period. Mention just enough stories to help the students to know a little about what went on during this time. We call the period the wandering in the wilderness until the Israelites cross Jordan into Canaan. At that point, they cross into the land of Canaan. Our link here is the idea that the Israelites did not wander in the wilderness forever; something brought the wandering in the wilderness to an end. It came to an end when they got where they were going, in other words, when they invaded and conquered the land of Canaan. Say the periods again. Remind them that we have two new ones to add: the Exodus, and the Wandering in the Wilderness. Don't forget them when we have said the first four. This is just a little memory help.

Invasion and Conquest of the Land

This period includes from the crossing of the Jordan until the death of Joshua. Our link with the next period is that, after Joshua, another generation arose that knew not the Lord. Israel became unfaithful. They repented and cried out for deliverance, and God sent them the _____. I am very alert to the knowledge level of a group as I teach. Many times, if I think they may know a fact, I will let the class fill in a blank. This technique helps to fasten the sequence in their minds. I always insist on saying the full name of the period during the learning process, even though, later, it can be shortened to merely "Invasion and Conquest." Name all the periods.

The Judges

From Othniel, the first judge, through Samuel. Link: Samuel was the last judge. In his days the people asked for a _____. Again, you have to have some idea of the capabilities of your class. If you do not think that they know that the people asked for a "King," then do not ask the question, but usually they will be able to fill in the blank. Name all the periods. Do not run a race saying them. Get

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into a rhythm and stick with it. Be sure to have everyone repeat the periods each time you add a new one.

The United Kingdom

If you name a kingdom the *United Kingdom*, that might suggest that something happened to that kingdom—that it *divided*. Over the United Kingdom three kings ruled: Saul, David, and Solomon. The link with the next period is that Solomon's unfaithfulness caused the kingdom to divide, resulting in the _____? By such broad hints and by vocal emphasis one can lead a group to see what comes next.

The Divided Kingdom

Now we have two kingdoms, Israel in the north and Judah in the south. This lasts for 200 years. Link: Here are Israel and Judah (I say this with a simple hand gesture in which I hold my hands one above another as if I were holding apples in them). The Assyrian empire came down and took the northern kingdom away leaving Judah alone. At this point I remove my upper hand and leave my lower hand in place. This gesture helps in drill work, because when I get to this point, using the simple hand gestures, I can say, "Assyria took Israel away leaving?" and the class can fill in "Judah alone" with no difficulty.

Judah Alone

Israel went away into captivity because of her sins. Link: Judah remained alone until they were taken into captivity, but Judah was taken away captive by the Babylonians. This mention of captivity prepares the way for the next period to be called the Captivity.

The Captivity

Judah in captivity. Here is where we have the stories of Daniel. Link: the people of Judah did not remain in captivity forever. At some point they *returned*. So what do we call the next period?

The Return

First return under Zerubbabel, with Jeshua, Haggai, and Zecha-

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riah. Story of Esther. Second return under Ezra. Followed by Nehemiah and the prophet Malachi. Link: after the return, the people failed to measure up to God's plan for them. He had no further vision or revelation for them until the time for Christ. Amos the prophet foretold a famine of hearing the word of the Lord (Amos 8:11). In other words, there would be a time of silence. The next period, because of the absence of any revelation from God, is called "The Years of Silence." Remember that at this point you are not trying to remember the names of all these people. They are being given so that you have a little understanding of what the "Return" is about. If you don't get it all this time, don't worry; this is not the last time we will go over this material. All of these things will be further reinforced.

The Years of Silence

The four hundred years between Malachi and Matthew. We could call these years "The Inter-testamental Period," but the term would be intimidating to many beginners. Besides it really was not an "inter-testamental period," since there was no gap of time between the Old Law and the New Law. Nor was it "Between the Covenants." The language of Amos 8:11 leads us to the simple, but descriptive, name by which we call this period. Link: the years of silence were brought to an end when God began his revelation again in connection with the life of _____. Most any class could answer this question. For this first cycle, you need very little emphasis on the designations for the last three periods.

The Life of Christ

As the term says, here we have the life of Christ recorded in the four gospel accounts. Our link is to emphasize that one of the principle things Jesus came to do was to establish the church.

The Early Church

The history of the early church is described in the book of Acts. Our link with the next period is that during the time of the writing of Acts, and afterward, for the rest of the first century, various letters were written to Christians.

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Letters to the Christians

The letters were written to churches and to individuals, but they were all Christians. Since "Christians" is the more inclusive term, we use it for this last heading.

After saying all of the periods and categories forward maybe a couple of times, lead the class to say them backwards. If linking has been done properly, they will be able to do it backwards as easily as forwards. Say, Letters to the Christians. But before there could be Christians, Christ had to establish the _____. (Early Church.) Pause before each heading and let the class fill in the blank if they can. And before the early church we have the Life of _____. And before the Life of Christ we have the Years of _____. And before the Years of Silence, we have the Return from Captivity. Before the *Return* from Captivity, we have the Captivity. Before Captivity, we have Judah Alone, and before that the Divided Kingdom. Before the Divided Kingdom comes the United Kingdom. Before the United Kingdom comes the Judges. Before the Judges, we have the Invasion and Conquest of the Land. Before the Invasion and Conquest, we have the Wandering in the Wilderness, and before that the Exodus. Before the Exodus we have the Patriarchs, and before the Patriarchs was the Tower of Babel. Before the Tower of Babel we have the Flood, and before the Flood, we have Before the Flood. The way we introduce these last two brings a smile, but it also makes the point that these terms are not just cold facts. These names of the periods are linked together to help remember them.

Second Cycle Contents of the Periods of History

As you begin this cycle, remember that we are reinforcing the first cycle, but we are also adding the content of these periods, so that you will have a grasp of what is in each period. Remind yourself of the things that link these periods together. If you are teaching this material, always beware of overloading the student's memory. You will see that the list of events in each period is not necessarily exhaustive. At this point we are not interested above all in the student's memorizing every event in the period. The idea is to give the class some idea of what is in this period. If they have a good smattering, all you will have to do is to remind them of these events and show how they are grouped. If they do not have even a smattering, then it is necessary to give little thumbnail surveys of the stories. Emphasize constantly: if you didn't get it the first time, don't worry. This is not the last time we will go over this material. But it is extremely important not to start in trying to memorize all these events from the beginning.

This cycle will take several classes. Each cycle doubles or triples the time necessary to learn the material. How you allot the classes to each cycle depends on how many class periods you will have in the quarter. If both Sunday morning and Wednesday night are devoted to the study, you can do it adequately. If only one class per week is devoted to it, you will not be able to get the job done unless there is already a good Bible knowledge among the students. Drill on the first cycle, but drill on the second cycle more. Each class, drill what you have covered, then add some more. Toward the end of the study of the second cycle, emphasize more heavily the ability to recite the list of events provided in this material.

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The first four of the periods are simple and are better known by most people. So do little more than mention the stories, unless you find you are dealing with people with no knowledge at all. Guard against going into much detail.

Before the Flood

- Creation of the world.
- Adam and Eve in the garden.
- First sin.
- Cain and Abel.
- Generations: transition from creation stories to Noah and the flood.

The Flood

- The flood itself.
- Meat given for food.
- Law of capital punishment.
- Covenant of the rainbow.
- Curse on Canaan.
- Generations: transition from flood to the scattering of the people.

Scattering of the People

- Tower of Babel built.
- Languages divided.
- Generations: transition to patriarchs.

The Patriarchs

- Abraham
- Isaac
- Jacob
- Story of Joseph: transition to the period of the Exodus. Remember to distinguish the book of Exodus from the period of the Exodus.

The events in the next two periods will be less familiar to your students. They may have heard of a lot of the stories, but they will often have little or no idea when these things happened.

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The Exodus

- Israel in bondage.
- Moses' birth.
- Raised as son of Pharaoh's daughter.
- Rejected by his people.
- Flees to wilderness.
- Burning bush.
- Plagues.
- Crossing of the Red Sea.
- Trip to Sinai.
- Events at Mount Sinai.
- Trip to Kadesh.
- Spies sent into the land.
- Israel refuses to go in.

Wandering in the Wilderness

The events in the wandering in the wilderness are scattered through Numbers with a very few in Deuteronomy, and in the first few chapters of Joshua. My point is that these events are a little difficult to search out and will be among the most unfamiliar to students in general.

- Israel sentenced to wander in the wilderness.
- Korah, Dathan, Abiram.
- Aaron's rod that budded.
- Miriam dies.
- Sin of Moses and Aaron.
- Passing by Edom.
- Aaron's death.
- Fiery serpents.
- Conquer Sihon (Amorites).
- Conquer Og (Bashan).
- Balaam.
- Fornication with Midianites.
- Second census.
- Slaughter of Midianites.
- Speeches of Moses in Deuteronomy.

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- Moses' death.
- Crossing of the Jordan.
- Observing the Passover.

Invasion and Conquest

- Central campaign:
 - They take Jericho, Bethel, and Ai.
 - They stake their claim on the land at Shechem.
- Southern campaign:
 - They make a treaty with the Gibeonites,
 - Then fight the kings of the south.
- Northern campaign:
 - They fight the kings of the north, led by Jabin king of Hazor.
- Land distributed among the tribes.
- Trans-jordanic tribes return home.
- Joshua challenges Israel to keep from the idols and to be faithful to God.
- Joshua challenges Israel to choose whom they will serve;
- They renew their covenant with Jehovah.

Judges

Most people will know very few of the judges, if any. Emphasize the best known, such as Gideon and Samson, but as the drill continues, include more, with a few identifying facts about them.

- Othniel.
- Ehud.
- Shamgar.
- Deborah.
- Gideon.
- Abimelech (not a judge, but a leader).
- Tola.
- Jair.
- Jephthah.
- Ibzan.

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- Elon.
- Abdon.
- Samson.
- Eli.
- Samuel.
- Story of Micah.
- Levite's concubine.
- Book of Ruth fits into this period.

There is so much information in the next few periods I do not try to list all the events. Just get in mind who and what these periods are about.

United Kingdom

- Saul.
- David.
- Solomon.

Divided Kingdom

- Kingdom of Israel in the north.
- Kingdom of Judah in the south.
- Period lasts 200 years until Israel in the north is taken away into captivity.
- Obadiah, Joel, Amos, Hosea, Isaiah, and Micah prophesy.
- Isaiah continues into the time of Judah alone.

Mention these prophets just to let the students know they fit into this period. As you continue to drill, you can work on remembering them a little more, but such things are not our present emphasis.

Judah Alone

- Kings: Hezekiah, Manasseh, Josiah.
- Prophets: Zephaniah, Jeremiah, Habakkuk, Nahum.

Captivity

- Daniel and Ezekiel.

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Return

Start out emphasizing the three returns, one under Zerubbabel and Jeshua, one under Ezra, and one under Nehemiah. Place Esther. Drill on these simple points first. Then associate the year of each return. Then add the other names, such as Haggai and Zechariah, Mordecai, Haman, Malachi. Remember how important it is to introduce the information a bit at the time, and review often to incorporate it into your knowledge. Continue to emphasize oral drill rather than everyone frantically writing everything down.

- Zerubbabel (536 B.C.) along with Jeshua the high priest, with around 50,000 Jews.
- Prophets: Haggai and Zechariah.
- Jews started building the temple,
- Were stopped after one year.
- Enemies waited until Cyrus was dead, then wrote to Cambyses about Jerusalem.
- He ordered building stopped.
- Prophets Haggai and Zechariah stirred the people to build the temple (520-516 B.C.).
- Esther fits in between Ezra chapters 6 and 7, about 485 B.C.
- Ezra leads a return (458 B.C.).
- Concentrates on purifying the worship.
- Nehemiah comes to build the walls of Jerusalem (445 B.C.).
- Malachi, the last prophet of the Old Testament (432 B.C.).

When you teach this period, emphasize the people, then the dates. This time through, do not worry about fixing the dates in mind. Use them only as a frame of reference. Have the people be able to name the people in connection with the first return (Zerubbabel, Jeshua, Haggai, Zechariah), with the story of Esther (Esther, Mordecai, Ahasuerus, Haman), the second return (Ezra), and the return of Nehemiah (Nehemiah, Malachi). Sometimes I do not even include Haman and Ahasuerus just to simplify. Then I can say we have nine people to remember during this period.

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Remember that this second cycle takes more time to fix in mind than the first. When you deal with a period as little known by most people as the Return is, it is far better to go over it several times. Start out first emphasizing that we have four episodes or parts in this period: the first return under Zerubbabel (536 B.C.), next the story of Esther (485 B.C.), then the second return under Ezra (458 B.C.), and fourth the story of Nehemiah's rebuilding the walls of Jerusalem (445 B.C.). Make sure everyone knows these episodes, and can recite them effortlessly. Then go back and add Jeshua the high priest to Zerubbabel during the first return, add Mordecai to Esther, and gradually go back and add the prophets, etc.

Years of Silence

Generalize at first. Make it simple. This period is also one of the least familiar to Bible students. The Persian empire was the one under which all of the characters listed in the Return lived. That empire lasted almost exactly a hundred years after the writing of Malachi.

At the end of the Persian Empire Alexander establishes the Hellenistic (Greek) empire. His conquests took about twelve or thirteen years. When he dies the empire fell into several warring parts. For our purposes, the conflicts between the kingdoms of Syria and Egypt are most important. Their struggles place Judea in the middle and, when Syria wins out and seeks to convert the Jews to the worship of the Greek God, Zeus, rebellion breaks out led by the family of Mattathias. The Maccabean revolt comes as Rome is extending its power eastward. In the last century before Christ, more and more Rome plays a dominant part. Just go over this basic, simple story over and over until you have it in mind. Then you will have no problem with the events listed below. It will help to use a map, and remember, keep it simple. Do not go into any detail about Alexander's horse Bucephalus or any other detail you can leave out. Remind the people they do not have to memorize all these names; just get a feeling for what was going on during the period.

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- Fall of the Persian Empire.
- Rise of the Grecian Empire.
- Splintering of the Grecian Empire.
- The Seleucid empire (Syria and Mesopotamia) battles the Ptolemaic kingdom (Egypt) for control of Palestine.
- Beginning of the Maccabean revolt.
- The development of parties such as the Pharisees, Sadducees, and Essenes.
- Rome comes to the Eastern Mediterranean.
- Herod the Great is given the kingdom of Judea, which includes virtually all of Palestine.

Life of Christ

Drill the students until they can list the seven periods of Jesus' life. Remember, it will accomplish nothing if they simply have this material lying in a drawer at home. Oral drill in class is of vital importance. There are other outlines of the Life of Christ, but this is a simple one, and variations can be learned later.

- Years of Preparation.
- Beginning of his ministry.
- Great Galilean Ministry.
- Periods of Retirement.
- Close of his ministry.
- Last Week.
- Resurrection Days.

Early Church

- Stories of Acts.
- Book covers a span of about 30 years.
- Acts 1-12:
 - Primarily the work in Jerusalem, Palestine, and the eastern end of the Mediterranean.
 - Covers about 15 years.
- Acts 13-28:
 - Primarily the work of Paul.

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- The spread of the gospel into all of the Roman empire.
- Covers about 15 years.

The point here is not to learn the chapter divisions of Acts but to help the student learn what the book is about. If they can learn that the book of Acts tells about the history of the early church covering about thirty years, they will have learned what they need to know in this cycle. Nevertheless, exposing them to this information here will help them when they are exposed to it more emphatically in the third cycle.

Letters to Christians

- Includes all the epistles and Revelation because all of these were written to Christians, some to churches and some to individuals, but all to Christians.
- Six of these were written during the time described in the book of Acts:
 - 1 and 2 Thessalonians
 - Galatians
 - 1 and 2 Corinthians
 - Romans

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what is in the chapters. Help everyone remember what is the first event and the last event in a given period and then find those events. This is the way that the scriptural limits are established.

Before the Flood — Genesis 1-5.

- Chapter 1: Creation of the world.
- Chapter 2: Adam and Eve in the Garden of Eden.
- Chapter 3: First sin.
- Chapter 4: Cain and Abel.
- Chapter 5: Generations of Adam.
- Fast forwards us to the time of the flood.

One of the purposes covered by the generations is to help us to see that the Bible is leading us to the life of one man—Jesus Christ. The Bible is his story. But, as a narrative device, the generations also help us to cover many years quickly, so think of it as fast forwarding. Also remember how we learned as children to count by fives: five, ten, fifteen—but all we have to count to remember the generation chapters is five, ten.

Flood — Genesis 6-10.

- Chapters 6-8: the flood itself.
- Chapter 9:
 - Meat for food.
 - Capital punishment.
 - Rainbow covenant.
 - Noah's drunkenness.
- Chapter 10: Generations of Noah's sons.
- Fast-forwards us to time of tower of Babel.

Early in our study of this third cycle, I keep it pared down to the minimum, but as we spend several classes drilling and fixing these scriptures in mind, I go a little more into detail and have the students learn that chapter 6 is the warning of the flood, chapter 7 is the beginning of the flood, and chapter 8 is the end of the flood.

Third Cycle

Scriptural Limits of the Bible Periods

The objective in this third cycle is to reinforce yet again the list of Bible periods, to reinforce the links between the periods, to reinforce what is in each of these periods, and to show where each Bible period is set forth in Scripture. In this section we show that outlining is not inspired; it is for our convenience. One may outline a period differently than someone else. One may choose a different event to mark the end or beginning of two periods. As long as one has logical reasons for so doing, it is all right to organize material differently. Illustrate at appropriate points. During the learning process be consistent and have everyone learn the same outline. Later, individuals may modify the outline. Also remember that, in order to keep the following outline as simple as possible, we ignore partial chapters.

To encourage my students I like to make the point that when they have learned the events listed for the first three periods, they will have learned what each of the first eleven chapters in Genesis is about. Remember that the "generations" chapters are 5 and 10. The last part of chapter 11 is also generations. In the previous cycles we do not look at our Bibles, but it is important to have people look at these divisions in their Bibles. Do not get detoured into detailed studies during this cycle. If someone asks a question that can be quickly and easily answered, do so. If it is way off the subject, or would require a very lengthy answer, remind the students that this study is preparatory for a more intense study later. Let's save our involved questions for that study.

As you help the students look for the Scriptures that begin and end the period, have them turn the pages quickly and just note

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Scattering of the People — Genesis 11

- Tower of Babel.
- Generations of Shem.
- Fast forwards us to time of the Patriarchs.

The Patriarchs — Genesis 12-50

- Chapters 12-25: Abraham.
- Chapters 25-28: Isaac.
- Chapters 28-35: Jacob.
- Chapter 36: Esau.
- Chapters 37-50: Joseph.

Be sure to turn the pages to see that the characters fit into the chapters given. In the period of the patriarchs emphasize most of all the overall period set forth in chapters 12-50. A little later break it down into the lives of the four characters set forth in these chapters. These Scriptures set forth the section where each patriarch is the main character, not the point from which his life begins to the time his life ends. At this point I like to have a surprise for the class and show them that, unbeknownst to them, they have learned a fine outline of the book of Genesis. Then I show how useful this is. Mention any story, or any promise to anybody in Genesis. If that story or that promise is about Abraham, where will it be found? Somewhere in Genesis 12-25, etc. I have found this a very encouraging experience for the student.

The Exodus — Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers 1-13

At first, just ask what this period begins with (Israel in bondage in Egypt) and what it ends with (the refusal of the people to go up and take the land). Fix the references in mind through oral drill. I do not make a very serious effort to learn a complete breakdown as is listed below, but eventually it needs to be done. Let time and your class's success be your guide. Do not forget how important it is for you and/or your students to page through their Bibles to see for themselves where these limits are.

- Exodus 1-15: Escape from Egypt.

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- Exodus 16-18: Journey to Mount Sinai.
- Exodus 19-24: God makes a covenant with Israel.
- Exodus 25-30: Instructions for making the tabernacle and its furniture.
- Exodus 31: Two special craftsmen who will direct the work.
- Exodus 32-34: Israel breaks their covenant; God renews it.
- Exodus 35-40: Building of the tabernacle and setting it up.
- Book of Leviticus:
 - Laws given for the priests and Levites.
 - Teaches concept of holiness.
- Numbers 1-9:
 - Census taken of people.
 - Gifts of princes.
 - Passover observed.
 - One year since left Egypt.
- Numbers 10-12: Trip from Sinai to Kadesh-barnea.
- Numbers 13: Spies bring back a fearful report.

Wandering in the Wilderness

(Numbers 14-36, Deuteronomy, Joshua 1-5)

Just as we said above, emphasize Numbers 14-Joshua 5. Add the rest as there is time. Count it a success if you and the students know the references for the beginning and the end of the periods. You will see that some chapters are skipped in the following list. As you turn the pages of your Bible, you will find that the chapters skipped are dealing with the law and not with the narrative. Also, a few events are skipped just to try as much as possible to keep it simple. Remember that by now, you and/or your students should be getting a lot more familiar with these events, so the memory load in this cycle will not be too great.

- Numbers 14: People sentenced to wander in the wilderness.
- Numbers 16: Korah, Dathan, Abiram.
- Numbers 17: Aaron's rod that budded.
- Numbers 20:

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- Miriam's death.
- Sin of Moses and Aaron.
- Passing by Edom.
- Death of Aaron.
- Numbers 21:
 - Fiery serpents.
 - Sihon.
 - Og.
- Numbers 22-24:
 - Balaam.
- Numbers 25: Israel commits fornication with Midianite women.
- Numbers 26: Second census.
- Numbers 31: Vengeance of Jehovah upon the Midianites.
- Book of Deuteronomy:
 - Speeches of Moses.
 - Moses' death.
- Joshua 1-4: Crossing the Jordan.
- Joshua 5: Observance of the Passover.
 - Exactly 40 years after leaving Egypt.

Invasion and Conquest (Joshua 4-24)

Joshua 4-24 is the main reference. Learn the others as time and interest permit.

- Chapters 4-8: Central campaign.
- Chapters 9-10: Southern campaign.
- Chapter 11: Northern campaign.
- Chapter 12: List of kings conquered.
- Chapters 13-19: Land divided.
- Chapters 20-21: Cities of refuge and other cities given to the priests and Levites.
- Chapter 22: Transjordanic tribes return home.
- Chapter 23: Joshua challenges Israel to forsake idols and to remain faithful to Jehovah.
- Chapter 24 - Covenant renewed at Shechem.

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Judges (Judges, Ruth, 1 Samuel 1-9 [up until Saul is anointed king])

- The first 13 judges are told about in the book of Judges.
- Stories of Eli and Samuel are told only in 1 Samuel.

I like to use 1 Samuel to illustrate my point about organization. If I organize 1 Samuel according to content, then I like to say it is about three men: Samuel, Saul, and David. The first eight chapters are primarily about Samuel, chapters 9-15 are primarily about Saul, and chapters 16-31 are primarily about David. If I want to divide 1 Samuel chronologically, then I say the first 9 chapters finish the period of the judges. Chapters 10-31 are the United Kingdom and the reign of Saul. One thing that encourages learning is to take data learned and require the mind to sort it in different ways. 1 Samuel furnishes an excellent opportunity for this. *Oral drill will fix these details in mind. Do not be discouraged. Give yourself time and keep working.*

In a way, the greatest challenge in learning the scriptural limits of each Bible period occurs in the next three periods. The main difficulty is that there are two parallel accounts. A second difficulty is that there is an awful lot of information to keep up with.

United Kingdom

- 1 Samuel 10-1 Kings 11.
- We have learned that 1 Samuel 9 is the end of the Judges, so the United Kingdom begins with 1 Samuel 10. Look in your Bible and see what chapter 10 tells about (*the anointing of Saul*).
- Now turn the pages through 2 Samuel and 1 Kings until you find the death of Solomon. What chapter is his death recorded in? This chapter, then marks the end of the United Kingdom.
- Now we need to look at the parallel account.

I sometimes call these parallel narratives A narrative and B narrative, and sometimes first narrative and second narrative.

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Just be sure your students know what you mean by whatever term you use.

Also take the time to show your students that narrative A begins in Genesis and proceeds from one book to the next book until 1 Chronicles. This is the main narrative. Then in 1 and 2 Chronicles we have a very important parallel narrative that we call narrative B, or second narrative. The reason why I use these terms is it is quicker to say A narrative than to say 1 and 2 Samuel, and 1 and 2 Kings. The main thing is that your students know that we have to deal with parallel accounts through these periods.

- **1 Chronicles 10-2 Chronicles 9:**
- In the parallel account we find Saul's death in 1 Chronicles 10.
- We find the death of Solomon in 2 Chronicles 9. So that chapter marks the close of the United Kingdom.
- (*This is the main part to emphasize.*)

Now let's give the references for each individual king who ruled over the United Kingdom.

- Saul:
 - 1 Samuel 10: Saul is anointed king.
 - 1 Samuel 31: Saul's death.
 - Therefore the life of Saul is set forth in 1 Samuel 10-31.
- When we go to the parallel account in 1 Chronicles:
 - The first nine chapters are given to genealogical records.
 - The only reference to Saul in 1 Chronicles is his death in chapter 10.
 - Therefore almost everything we know about Saul is in 1 Samuel.
- David:
 - David is king throughout almost the entire book of 2 Samuel.
 - He is anointed king over Judah at the beginning of chapter 2. Therefore for convenience sake, think of David's reign as being told in 2 Samuel.

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- He lives on into 1 Kings, but he makes Solomon his successor in chapter one of that book. Again, we emphasize that David's reign is almost completely confined to 2 Samuel. Leave the little details until later.
- In 1 Chronicles, we find David's rule from chapter 11 through chapter 29.
- Solomon:
 - In the Kings narrative, Solomon is made king in 1 Kings 1 and dies in chapter 11, so 1 Kings 1-11 is the reign of Solomon.
 - In the Chronicles account, Solomon begins his rule in 2 Chronicles 1, and his death is recorded in chapter 9. Therefore Solomon's reign is set forth in 2 Chronicles 1-9.

Divided Kingdom

- 1 Kings 12-2 Kings 17:
 - Since the divided kingdom begins after the death of Solomon, in the first narrative it starts in 1 Kings 12,
 - And it ends with the northern kingdom of Israel being carried away into captivity, it ends in 2 Kings 17.
- 2 Chronicles 10-29:
 - In the second narrative, since the death of Solomon is in 2 Chronicles 9, the divided kingdom begins in chapter 10.
 - The close of the Divided Kingdom is not as clearly set forth in 2 Chronicles as it is in 2 Kings. Our best estimate is chapter 29.

I cannot over-emphasize how important it is to have the students leaf through their Bibles to find these events that mark the beginning and end of these periods. That way they see that these divisions are based on fact.

Drill, drill, drill. Have everyone go through the process several times of looking up the references as described above. Then require more and more response from memory.

This is the period when the writing prophets began their work,

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but I do not take time to emphasize their work on this time through the material, lest it seem overwhelming to the student. The prophets can be added later.

Judah Alone

- 2 Kings 18-25:
- Since Judah alone follows the fall of Israel, and Israel is taken away in 2 Kings 17, Judah alone begins in 2 Kings 18.
- It closes with the fall of Jerusalem and the captivity in chapter 25.
- 2 Chronicles 29-36:
- Likewise, in the second narrative, since the fall of Israel probably happens about the time of 2 Chronicles 29, Judah alone begins in chapter 30,
- And continues to the end of the book, chapter 36.

Captivity (The Books of Daniel and Ezekiel)

I like to point out that there is actually an over-lapping of the periods of Judah alone and the Captivity, because the captivity began before Judah fell. Captives such as Daniel and his friends were carried away in 2 Kings 24, and 2 Chronicles 36, as was Ezekiel, but to keep it simple, I just emphasize that Daniel and Ezekiel are where we get our information about the captivity and go into no more detail than this.

Return (The books of Ezra, Haggai, Zechariah, Esther, Nehemiah, and Malachi)

- Ezra 1-6: The first return in 536 B.C. under Zerubbabel and Jeshua (the high priest).
- They rebuild the temple.
- Books of Haggai and Zechariah: At that same time Haggai and Zechariah prophesy.
- Book of Esther:
- The story of Esther occurs between Ezra 6 and 7.
- Ezra 7-10: Second return, under Ezra, 458 B.C.
- Book of Nehemiah:

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- Nehemiah comes in 445 B.C. to rebuild the walls of Jerusalem.
- Book of Malachi: The period ends with his work.

Having emphasized the people in the Return earlier, now let's pull the books together. There are Ezra, Haggai, Zechariah, Esther, Nehemiah, and Malachi. *Drill until the students can list the times of the returns, the people of the returns, and the books of the return.*

Years of Silence (No Scripture)

I go into no detail in this cycle on the last three periods. The years of silence have no Scriptures to learn, and most people are familiar with Matthew, Mark, Luke, John, and Acts. Then, whether they can say the epistles or not, they at least can find that they all follow Acts.

Life of Christ — Gospel accounts.

Early church — Acts.

Letters to Christians — Epistles and Revelation.

Fourth Cycle — A Lifetime of Study

Often I am asked, "What is the next cycle?" It is the most important cycle of all. If you have been following this outline carefully, you now have the "boxes ready in the warehouse," the "files ready on your hard drive," the "skeleton" ready for all future Bible study.

The next cycle is learning what is in every chapter, learning every story in detail, learning the message of every prophet and of every epistle. Go back and get well acquainted with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. Walk with Moses and the Israelites through the Red Sea. Stand with them at the foot of Mount Sinai and hear Jehovah speak aloud. Walk through that "great and terrible wilderness" to Kadesh-barnea. Then cross the Jordan with them into the promised land. Watch Samson lift those gates of Gaza and carry them over hill and dale to the hill just outside the walls of Hebron. Let David become one of your best friends. Weep as the kingdom falls apart, and as

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those kingdoms become more and more wicked. Stand in the streets of Israel and hear Amos and Hosea cry out their messages of doom. Ask the question of "why" with Habakkuk and hear God's answer. Weep with Jeremiah as he stands looking at the deserted, wasted city of Jerusalem. Rejoice — and yet weep — as the temple is rebuilt in Zerubbabel's day. Then live through the years of silence when God seems to ignore His people by sending no prophet. Stand beside the altar of incense with Zacharias and hear an angel speak for the first time in over 400 years. Rejoice with the shepherds as the angels announce the birth of the long awaited Messiah. Let Jesus become your most intimate friend. Stand in awe at the empty tomb. Hear the sound of the coming of the Holy Spirit on the day of Pentecost and listen to Peter proclaim the gospel for the first time. Watch as the early church grows — and then is persecuted and scattered. But see that hardship only makes it grow faster. Walk with Paul over all Asia Minor. Sing with him in the dungeon at Philippi. Sit beside him as he writes to fellow-saints and pours out his heart to them, to help them overcome some problem or to grow in their understanding of some concept about this new kingdom of the Lord. Finally stand with John on the island of Patmos and see the marvels of the great revelation, the beautiful glimpse of the final victory of the Lord and his saints.

It is a lifelong goal. It is one that can be accomplished, and it is infinitely and eternally rewarding. The small effort is as nothing in comparison to the eternal weight of glory awaiting us (2 Cor. 4:16-18). "Thanks be to God for His indescribable gift" (2 Cor. 9:15)!

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Lamp To My Feet

You Shall Be My People, From Egypt to Canaan
In the Days of the Judges, Conquest and Judges
Give Us A King, United Kingdom and Wisdom Literature
Till There Was No Remedy, Divided Kingdom and Prophets
A Remnant Shall Return, Captivity, Return, Years of Silence
"Sir, We Would See Jesus," The Life of Christ
Go Tell the Good News,

The Early Church, Acts through 2 Timothy
"How Long, O Lord?" Hebrews through Revelation

Other Books

A Generation That Knows Not God,
A Teacher Training Manual.

Christ In You, The Hope of Glory,

The basic relationship God wants with men.

The History and Geography of the Bible Story,
A Study Manual for the Bible.

Tracts

Human Suffering

*The Unfolding of God's Plan
Relevance? Or Humanism?*

Do All Roads Lead to Heaven?

The Three Cycle Approach to Bible Study

Video

Three Cycle Approach to Learning Bible Chronology

An informal video of Bob illustrating how he teaches the material.